

Editorial

Let Big Brother watch

ALL OF US pored over the papers and were glued to the TV, as reports updated us on the sophistication of the Mumbai attacks. GPS devices, Russian re-mailer servers and Blackberry devices were used by the terrorists. It must have been infinitely easier to find someone to teach them how to use a GPS device or a Blackberry, than to fire an AK-47... even if they are, allegedly, from poor families in little villages. That's the beauty (or the horror, in this case) of technology today — absolutely anyone can learn to use it (for good or evil), with very little in terms of a formal education required.

While most of us have lambasted our politicians and intelligence agencies, and played armchair Prime Minister for a few days, the real question that remains to be answered is what are we willing to lose to make sure that our country and our way of life is more secure?

After events like 26/11, people are generally more accepting of security measures, and patiently wait in line to be scanned and patted down at public places. Unless you're a criminal, and are carrying drugs, guns or explosives, you have an air of acceptance about you when your "privacy" is being violated by these checks. "It's for the greater good", you say to yourself, and move on.

So why is it that you don't feel the same way about your online activities being monitored? Why is the world so paranoid about Big Brother, and the techniques he may employ to keep us in check?

I, for one, couldn't care less if my mails and social networking profiles were being monitored — personal IDs of course. Monitoring work communications might not be such a good idea, because most businesses survive on privacy and secrecy of intellectual properties, and leaks could ruin them. So, companies

could always choose to secure and encrypt their work mail, and not use "free email" services.

I expect people to brand me insane for welcoming the idea of Big Brother into my life, but I think it's only logical given the times we live in. I'd rather some government computer network pick out a billion innocent messages that we send, than let even a single mail from a terrorist go unnoticed.

What have we really got to hide? I'm sure the government or its computers will not care about how much porn you surf for — unless it's underage nonsense, in which case you deserve life imprisonment or worse. A government computer will not care about your affair with your secretary, or what you were up to on your last holiday either. Besides, with a billion people online world-wide, which government is really going to have time for irrelevant rubbish?

You've probably heard the phrase, "The internet's biggest flaw is also its biggest draw". This refers to the lack of a governing body for the net, and the freedom and anonymity it offers. Like little children in a fancy dress competition, we don different costumes online, and always wear a mask. However, terrorists, paedophiles, stalkers and other sick people do exactly the same thing. Isn't it time we started to realise that without some form of governance, chaos rules?

How is it a good thing that just anybody can Google "How to make a bomb" or "homemade bomb" and get over 4.4 crore and 4.5 lakh results, respectively? How can we shout about privacy and freedom, when some innocent eight-year old is being made to act out sick fetishes on film, by some of the same people who stand next to you in this self-righteous picket line?



Robert Sovereign-Smith, Editor

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YouTube videos that spread hatred, terrorists who use sat-phones, BlackBerry services, and Google Earth, paedophiles that lurk in chat rooms waiting to prey on your kids, and vengeful, lovelorn idiots making indecent profiles of their exes on networking sites; how much more idiocy do we really need to see before we welcome a change that will stop allowing the law to throw up its hands in helplessness whenever tech is involved in a crime? In this day and age, we need more preventive than reactive measures. I don't think my desire for "online privacy" is stronger than my desire to never again bear witness to a sorrowful candlelight vigil at the Gateway of India.

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